



A mural by José Clemente Orozco (1883–1949) depicting Miguel Hidalgo, whose anticolonial document sparked the Mexican War of Independence.



A caricature compares the Luddites to mobs of the French Revolution.



When Napoleon Bonaparte's troops arrived in Moscow, they found the city ablaze, as portrayed by this painting by Jean-Charles Langlois (1789–1870).

KEY

- Spanish territory
- Portuguese territory

Latin America on the eve of independence

Spain and Portugal still controlled the majority of Central and South America during the early days of the Peninsular War.



USING THE EXISTING POLITICAL CHAOS

as an opportunity for reform, Spanish politicians called a congress, known as a **Cortes**, on September 24 in the port of Cadiz. Deputies numbered 104, with 30 representing the colonial territories, although more arrived later. The Cortes declared itself the source of national sovereignty and began to draw up a constitution, although Spaniards were divided as to the extent they wished the government to be restructured. There was also the question of how much political **representation** to allow overseas territories. The colonies represented a population far greater than Spain's, meaning they could, in theory, dominate the Cortes. The peninsular politicians wished to avoid this, yet needed the colonies' continued support.

Some members of the public in the colonies began taking matters into their own hands. In Dolores, Mexico, a parish priest named **Miguel Hidalgo y Costilla** (1753–1811) distributed a

document calling for the end of Spanish rule, while advocating racial equality and land redistribution, an act known as the **Grito de Dolores** (Cry of Dolores). Thousands responded to his call and set off for Mexico City, where they were put down by loyalist troops the following year. But Hidalgo's actions had sparked the Mexican struggle for freedom.

In other Spanish colonies, similar upheavals took place. The viceroyalty of **New Granada** also declared its independence on July 20, and there had been uprisings in Quito and Buenos Aires.

Meanwhile, on the **Hawaiian islands** in the Pacific Ocean, **King Kamehameha I** (1758–1819) became the first ruler of a united Hawaii, helping the islands withstand European incursions.

ON JULY 5, THE SOUTH AMERICAN TERRITORY of Venezuela joined New Granada (see map, left) and Mexico in declaring independence from Spain. One of the rebels involved in the deliberations for independence, **Simón Bolívar** (see panel, below), had recently returned from England, where he had tried to elicit British support for their cause, but he was unsuccessful.

Bolívar's trip was confined to London, but had he traveled farther north, he would have seen rebels of another kind: the group known as the **Luddites**, who were attacking textile mills in the industrial north of England. The Luddites aimed to destroy the new machinery in the mills. They feared the machines would eventually **replace** them, thereby forcing them into unemployment and poverty.

SIMÓN BOLÍVAR (1783–1830)

Simón Bolívar was born in Caracas to a wealthy family. He was sent to Europe at 16, where he was inspired by the writings of Enlightenment thinkers on the issue of liberty. Soon after returning to South America in 1807, he became involved in independence conspiracies. Later known as **El Libertador**, he led much of northern South America to independence from Spain. He also ruled Gran Colombia, but the political union ultimately failed.



RUSSIA, LIKE PORTUGAL, DECIDED to resist Napoleon's **Continental System**, measures intended to damage the economy of Britain. Russia had withdrawn from it in 1810, and Napoleon resolved to mount an invasion in retaliation. He sent more than **500,000 troops** to Russia in June and won early victories at the battles of **Smolensk** on August 17 and **Borodino** on September 7, arriving with his forces in Moscow on September 14. There they found the city gutted, and its inhabitants gone. Russian troops held off any further advance, and as the brutal Russian winter set in, Napoleon's troops began to falter. The **Grand Armée** was running short on food and many soldiers, unaccustomed to such extreme cold, died. Napoleon had no other option but to make a

humiliating **retreat** in December. Only around 30,000 French soldiers survived.

In North America, merchants prospered in their trade with France, claiming to be a neutral party in the dispute between the British and the French. Britain refused to recognize this **neutrality** and began to seize American ships, often capturing the American sailors and pressing them into service with the British Royal Navy. This triggered the **War of 1812** (to 1814), which also included battles on the mainland where Britain persuaded American Indians loyal to the Crown to attack settlements in the Northwest Territory.

In Spain, the Cortes had finally produced a **constitution**. It limited the power of the monarchy—although Ferdinand VII was still in exile—and did not provide any special representation in the Cortes for the nobility or the clergy. Its liberal ideas provoked an angry reaction among some supporters of the Crown and

Church, and triggered a long-running fight between liberals and conservatives, which would continue for decades.

In Egypt, Muhammad Ali was ordered on a campaign to reestablish Ottoman rule in the holy city of **Mecca**, and drive out the Wahhabis, who had seized much of Arabia. His troops took Medina in 1812, and Jeddah and Mecca the following year.

Start of Spanish American revolutions: by 1826 all Spanish mainland colonies in South America have gained independence

Radama I (1793–1828) consolidates rule in Madagascar

Western Georgia annexed by Russia

King Kamehameha (1758–1819) unites Hawaiian islands

Spanish assembly (Cortes) meets in Cadiz and begin debating reforms

The Kingdom of Holland annexed to France

Britain occupies Seychelles and Mauritius

Mexican priest Miguel Hidalgo's Grito de Dolores revolt against Spanish authorities

George IV (1762–1830) becomes prince regent in Britain due to George III's deteriorating mental health

British textile workers, known as Luddites, wreck machinery in textile mills

Venezuela and Paraguay proclaim their independence from Spain

British retake Malacca from the Dutch

March 19 Spanish national assembly in Cadiz unveils a democratic constitution

Usman dan Fodio (1754–1815) establishes the Sokoto Caliphate in Nigeria

Napoleon's Russian campaign (to 1814)

War of 1812 between US and Britain, triggered by the seizure of American ships (to 1814)